



PTI PHOTO KAMAL SINGH



"Now Vote For Us",
March 17, 2008

"Budgets should not be planned with an eye on the polls. As long as the policies of the Centre are people-friendly, the parties will get the votes."

S. LAKSHMI, *on e-mail*

Poll Gimmicks

Manmohan Singh and Chidambaram have proved that they are politicians first and economists next ("Now Vote For Us", March 17). UPA can now heave a sigh of relief as the Budget has galvanised their cadre.
K.R. SRINIVASAN, *Chennai*

P. Chidambaram's relief package for large sections of the country's poor has made the right populist noises. It may have altered the country's political scenario, but has the Government ever thought about fair pricing, which may be a better option than loan waivers?
BIDYUT KUMAR CHATTERJEE, *Faridabad*

Ours is the only country where the budget is used to derive political mileage and where the policy-makers are not concerned about the welfare of the people.
RAMESH AGARWAL, *Delhi*

Chidambaram's loan waiver applies only to loans taken from banks. It is silent on those taken from private sources like the money lenders. This is the way the current regime looks at problems—ignore the basic issues and throw up palliatives.
MEGHANA A., *Hyderabad*

Politicians should not take their electorate for granted. Its poll debacles in various states should put the Congress leadership on its guard. Sonia Gandhi should concentrate more on strengthening the party machinery, which is woefully short on ideas.
D.B.N. MURTHY, *Bangalore*

After populist gimmicks in pre-poll budget, people should brace for rise in prices and increased taxes in the first post-poll budget when the new finance minister justifies them on the basis of empty treasury

and development in national interest.
SUBHASH C. AGRAWAL, *Delhi*

Loan waiver is of no use not only to those farmers who have borrowed from private money lenders and unjust to those who paid their loans in time. The waiver will only inspire the farmers not to repay their loans in future as well.
VIJAY DANDIWALA, *on e-mail*

The cover page of the issue was excellent and aptly proved that a picture is worth a thousand words. This budget is all set to act as a juicy carrot for the middle-class and the farmers who will again carry the weight of their masters for another five years.
RATAN SHARGA, *on e-mail*

Nuclear Unclear

It is high time the Left started cooperating with the Government in clinching the nuclear deal ("Nuclear Showdown", March 17).

The US has shown a lot of maturity in handling the issue and the Left should do the needful now. It is in the country's interest.
VIRENDRA KUMAR TANGRI, *Dehradun*

The UPA Government is in a Catch-22 situation. If it fails to sign the deal, the US will scuttle any chances of it getting an India-specific waiver from the NSG and if it does sign the deal, it will collapse.
NALINI VIJAYARAGHAVAN, *Thiruvananthapuram*

Not Worth their Salt

It was disheartening to read "The Wounds of Salt" (March 17). One felt surprised and anguished to see that even in this day and age, primitive methods are being used to extract salt. The Government should take effective steps to alleviate the poverty-stricken life style of these tribes.
ONKAR SINGH CHARAK, *Ambikapur, Chhattisgarh*